rationale for an Indian BMD capability, focusing on the insecurity of Pakistan's nuclear arsenal, Pakistan's ongoing attempts to coerce India by prosecuting a strategy of low-intensity conflict from behind the shield of nuclear deterrence, and the dangers of Pakistani horizontal nuclear proliferation, as exemplified by the activities of the A. Q. Khan network.[7] Rajesh Basrur goes further, maintaining that Indian leaders are *obligated* to pursue missile defense capabilities, since "it is incumbent upon the government to take at least some steps to protect its citizens against the small risk of deterrence failure by error, accident, or design."[8]

Such arguments are not without merit, particularly given concerns regarding the security of Pakistan's nuclear arsenal and the concomitant dangers of unauthorized Pakistani nuclear use. Nonetheless, we believe that, on balance, Indian missile defense would be strategically undesirable, even if it were technologically feasible and financially viable. The danger of missile defense, in our view, is essentially the same as that of counterforce nuclear capabilities.[9] During the Cold War, the United States and the Soviet Union developed nuclear weapons sufficiently accurate and powerful to destroy each other's nuclear forces, even when those forces were located in hardened silos. The main purpose of such "counterforce" weapons was to limit damage to the attacking state in the event of a nuclear conflict. If the attacker's counterforce could destroy a significant portion of its adversary's weapons while those weapons were still on the ground, the adversary's ability to harm the attacker would be proportionately reduced.[10]

Although this might appear to be an attractive outcome, counterforce actually had dangerous implications, threatening to create incentives for both sides to use nuclear weapons first in the event of a crisis. If the leaders of a state believed that striking their adversary first with counterforce could significantly limit the adversary's ability to harm them, they might be tempted to do so. And if the leaders of the adversary state anticipated being struck with counterforce, they might decide to launch their own weapons first, to prevent them from being destroyed on the ground. Counterforce also created incentives for both sides to arms race. The larger a state's nuclear arsenal, the more difficulty its adversary would have in